

coupon sales altogether. He was often quoted as saying, “There is no legitimate reason to buy coupons.” Really? I couldn’t imagine that he was a couponer. Surely an avid couponer would understand the need for extra coupons when imbibing in healthy stockpiling.

Jill Cataldo, however, is an avid coupon user. Cataldo—consumer advocate, coupon workshop instructor, and syndicated newspaper columnist—is a self-professed coupon maven. She has also become a voice of reason in the otherwise volatile world of “extreme couponing” and a vocal proponent of couponing ethics.

Through my extensive research, I’ve gradually, and somewhat reluctantly, come to the conclusion that Miller and Cataldo have a valid concern in regards to at least one of the various methods couponers employ in obtaining additional coupons: purchasing them through the mail, through websites like eBay, or coupon handling websites that offer a “clipping service.” “It’s a violation of the terms and conditions printed right there on the coupon,” Bud Miller said in a Tampa Bay online article.

Keeping in mind that I used to be one of the couponers who retrieved stray coupon inserts from a recycling center, it should come as no surprise that I’d also utilized coupon clipping services on occasion, albeit services from a source I knew and trusted. And yes, I’d also purchase extra coupons on eBay. Neither of these methods is technically illegal—yet. Avid couponers like me definitely can see a legitimate reason to obtain more coupons than those received in our own Sunday newspaper. How else can we stockpile peanut butter when it goes on sale for one dollar with a one dollar coupon available? Buying additional newspapers is an option I often